

Task Categorization Worksheet

Identify what's maintenance, optimization, or transformation

Level 1: Maintenance

KEEPS LIGHTS ON

Daily operational work that maintains existing systems and processes. Necessary but creates no new value. Can consume 70-80% of your day if unmanaged.

Characteristics:

- Anyone with basic training could complete this task
- Task is repetitive and routine
- Outcome is predictable and incremental
- Required for operations but doesn't move goals forward
- Can be batched, delegated, or automated

EXAMPLES:

→ Responding to routine emails

→ Attending standard status meetings

→ Filing reports or documentation

→ Data entry and admin tasks

→ Routine customer support

Your Level 1 Tasks (to batch/delegate/eliminate):

1

2

3

4

5

Level 2: Optimization

MAKES THINGS BETTER

Improvements to existing systems and processes. Creates incremental value (10-20% gains). Important but subject to diminishing returns. Better than maintenance but not transformational.

Characteristics:

- Improves existing workflows or systems
- Creates measurable but incremental gains
- Requires some expertise or experience
- Makes current operations more efficient
- Subject to law of diminishing returns

EXAMPLES:

- Streamlining an approval process
- Improving team communication protocols
- Refactoring code for better performance
- Tweaking marketing copy for higher CTR
- Reorganizing file structures

Your Level 2 Tasks (schedule strategically):

- 1 _____
- 2 _____
- 3 _____
- 4 _____
- 5 _____

Level 3: Transformation

CHANGES THE GAME

Game-changing work that creates exponential results. Moves you toward major goals and breakthroughs. Creates competitive advantages and opens new opportunities. THIS is your Three Things focus.

Characteristics:

- Creates exponential value (10x, not 10%)
- Requires deep focus and strategic thinking
- Only YOU can do this with your expertise
- Moves you toward transformational goals
- Will matter months or years from now
- Opens doors to new opportunities

EXAMPLES:

- Closing a major client/partnership deal
- Developing breakthrough product features
- Building strategic relationships
- Acquiring critical skills or knowledge
- Making decisions that shape strategy
- Creating intellectual property or assets

Your Level 3 Tasks (YOUR THREE THINGS):

1

2

3

4

5



Task Categorization Decision Framework

Q1: Would completing this task alone make today successful?

If YES → Likely Level 3. If NO → Level 1 or 2.

Q2: Could someone else do this with a 5-minute briefing?

If YES → Level 1 (delegate it). If NO → Level 2 or 3.

Q3: Will this matter a month from now? A year from now?

If NO → Level 1. If MONTH → Level 2. If YEAR → Level 3.

Q4: Does this create new value or just maintain existing systems?

MAINTAIN → Level 1. IMPROVE → Level 2. CREATE NEW → Level 3.

Q5: What's the potential impact?

0-10% gain → Level 1-2. 10-50% gain → Level 2. 2-10× impact → Level 3.

From the **Three Things Productivity System** | Signal/Noise

Focus 70% of your time on Level 3. Batch Level 1. Schedule Level 2 strategically.